Graphic Design

Mastering the Pen Tool

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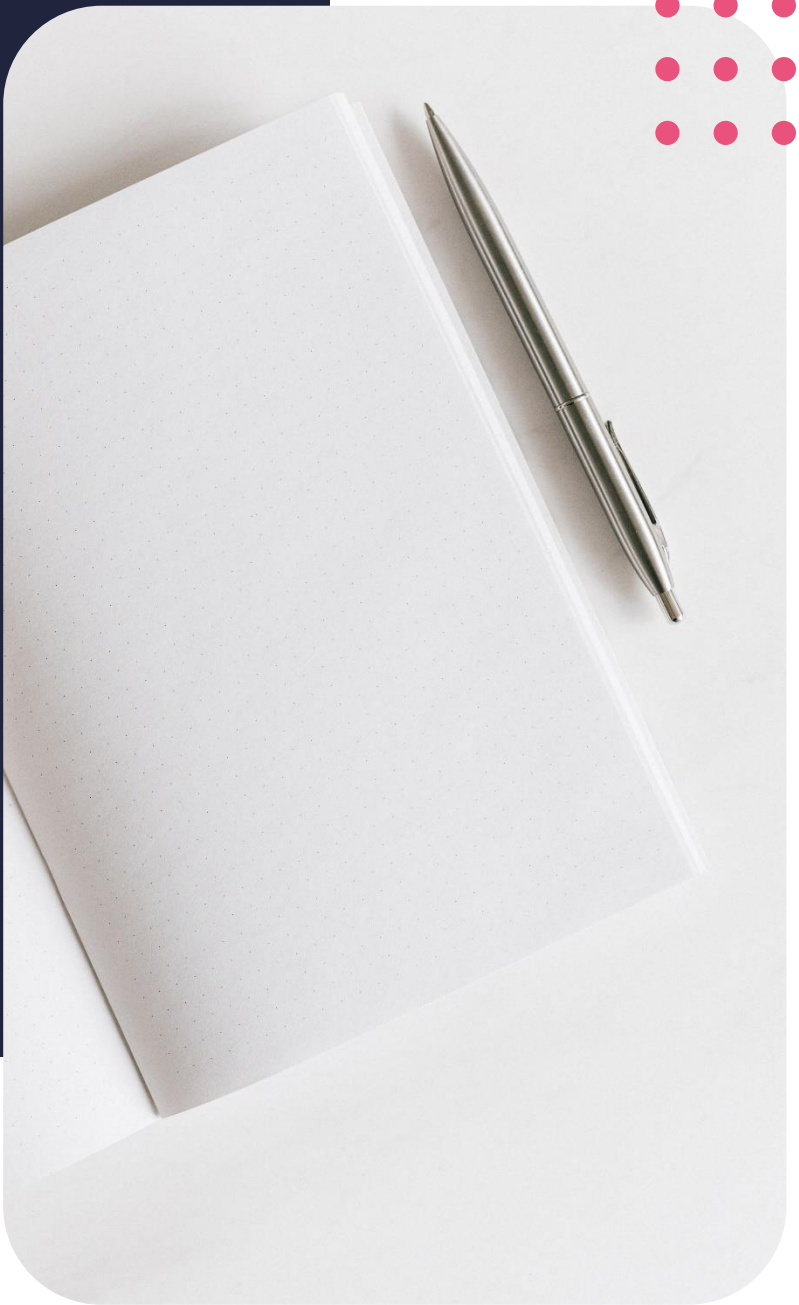


Lesson outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Lesson outcome 1: Create curves with a pen tool
- Lesson outcome 2: Reason to use a pen tool
- Lesson outcome 3: Pen tool demo

Introduction

Today's topic forms part of understanding the pen tool and we will specifically look at what the pen tool is and how to make use of it.

Did you know that some of the best ideas and inventions were at first ridiculed before they were accepted by the masses? Why do you think this is? It is because as soon as something is strange to someone, we tend to laugh at it. Some inventions like these are coffee, aeroplanes, umbrellas, and even the personal computer!

Back in the 1980's it was called computerphobia and people view owning a computer as a chore – something you must learn, like a music instrument.

Today, however, it is a necessity to understand a computer and being computer literate opens many doors for you. Computers are also a lot more user-friendly.

So, next time you have someone laughing at your ideas or concepts, take heart that they are just not familiar with the concept. Don't let the fear of what others might think dishearten you.

Creating curves with a pen tool

Creating curves with the pen tool is the most intimidating part but once you have mastered it, you will be able to create so many designs. The trick is to use a limited number of anchor points. Using too many anchor points will create a rough texture.

We have two types of curves when it comes to the pen tool: simple curves and complex curves.

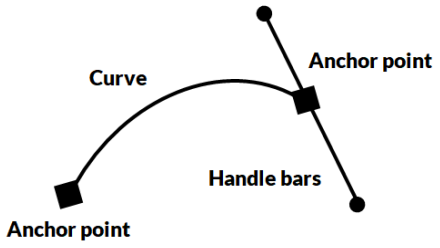
Simple curves

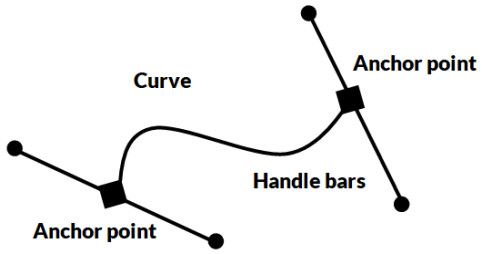
What we want to achieve with the pen tool. Complex curves, like the name implies, can be complex and will confuse you.

A simple curve consists out of only one curve.

A complex curve

Two curves that are created by adjusting the handle bars from your anchor points.





Why use a pen tool

I believe it is quite clear that the pen tool plays a crucial part when it comes to editing and designing.

The first reason for using the pen tool is that it is extremely accurate. In PS, we can use the pen tool to cut certain elements out of a photograph. I will show you different ways of cutting elements in Photoshop in our demo later and the pen tool will be the most accurate. It might take slightly longer than the magic wand tool or magnetic lasso tool, but the results speak for themselves.

In Illustrator, it is the most accurate way to draw or retrace elements.

The advantage of using the pen tool is that your paths and curves are editable and you can simply go back and re-edit your paths or curves if need be. It is a non-destructive way of designing and editing.

Pen tool demo

Please refer to the recording for the demo

Our first demo will be in Photoshop and we will create a floral letter design. I will be making use of stock images mostly and teach you different ways of cutting images or removing the background. We will then draw a basic shape with the pen tool and apply a clipping mask to it. I will round the design off with a marble background and add a shadow to my letter as well to give the image some depth. The final step is to take my design and create a greetings or birthday card. Basically, taking our awesome design and doing something with it. What's the use if we can't utilise our design? This comes in very handy when you want to get your files print-ready and perhaps next time, instead of buying a birthday or valentine's card, design your own!

Our second demo will also be in Photoshop and entails photo-manipulation using mostly the pen tool. We will take stock images in the form of glasses and a face and combine the two images. If you ever wondered what you would look like with glasses, this technique will teach you how to edit glasses onto a face.

The last demo will be in Illustrator and is based on digital illustration using the pen tool. As with the first demo, this will also entail the design for a birthday card. However, the techniques that you will learn in all these demos can be applied in a variety of designs and ways.

Conclusion

Our lesson today entailed a lot of practical demos and tools learnt. We looked at how to make use of the pen tool and we then created a floral letter in Photoshop using deep-etching with the pen tool. We did some photo-manipulation and added sunglasses to a face, and we ended off drawing with the pen tool in Illustrator.